

The social tribunal is fierce and fickle

How to change the rules of the infosphere

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At the end of the year we have just left behind, we witnessed what today appears – although it may not be so – as the swan song of Chiara Ferragni, who plummeted, at the speed of a shooting star, from the firmament of influencers to the dust of the worst among common mortals for having – at least according to the Antitrust authority – deceived consumers by claiming that if they purchased a panettone, part of the proceeds would go to charity when it was not the case.

The fierce social tribunal, in fact, condemned her without appeal in just a few days, to a punishment enormously more severe than the fine imposed by the Antitrust: infamy, the other side of fame.

This year, moreover, began with a completely different news story, with tones that are, unfortunately, much more dramatic but with some moments of contact, perhaps not negligible, with the first case still under investigation.

The story is that of Giovanna Pedretti, a restaurateur from Lodi, who died, possibly by suicide, perhaps unable to withstand a wave of social disgrace that overwhelmed her just hours after another wave, equally high, of popularity on social media that she herself had ridden.

Reduced to its essence, the story is this: a few days ago, the restaurateur published on social media a comment from a customer who complained about having to eat near a gay couple and a person with motor difficulties, and below, her response inviting the customer in question not to frequent her restaurant anymore, given his inhumanity.

For social media, for newspapers, for television, and for the world of politics, Giovanna became, in a handful of hours, a national champion of civility and humanity.

But it didn't last long.

Less than a day later, Lorenzo Biagiarelli, a food blogger and partner of journalist Selvaggia Lucarelli, published a post questioning Pedretti's: perhaps the insensitive and inhumane comment from the customer was fabricated because a series of elements did not add up; perhaps, despite appearances, it was just a publicity stunt. The wind, which changes on social media at the same speed as that which blows in the Caribbean, reversed direction and raised a wave of insults directed at Giovanna.

Then came the suicide.

A few hours later, accusations were directed at the Biagiarelli-Lucarelli couple for having driven Giovanna to suicide and their defenses: seeking the truth and informing does not mean instigating anyone to suicide. It is inappropriate, today, to dwell on these aspects of the story. We know too little about Giovanna's death, the validity of the accusations made against her, the relentlessness with which they were made, and the admitted relationship that there is – between events that the calendar presents in a certain correlation.

And yet there is one fact: in less than 72 hours, a woman was exalted on social media and condemned to media disgrace, according to some, even condemned to death for the unsustainability, at least in the subjective dimension, of the disgrace.

Just like in Ferragni's case – a completely different story, it is worth remembering – the distance between the stars and the stables, in the digital dimension, appears close to zero or, better, to the so-called real-time, the time in which everything happens online.

This is a realization that perhaps deserves some further reflection. The first is simple: personal reputation, in the digital dimension, is ephemeral and fragile. It takes little to gain fame, but even less to be condemned to infamy. The second is related to the first: the social tribunal is fierce and fickle, changes its mind in a few moments, and supports thesis and antithesis with the same determination, the same force of impact, the same impetus. The third is more important than the first two: reputation, for people – even if with different intensity – is like the air we breathe. If it is rich in oxygen, it gives us strength and energy; if it is polluted or contaminated, it wears us down and can lead us to death.

Beware of forgetting this, beware of taking it lightly, beware of confusing the immateriality of certain words with that of their consequences because there are words that hurt more than blows. And then there is a fourth: trials are held in court, not on television, not in newspapers, and not on social media, and, above all, media disgrace is not a sanction that is humanly and democratically sustainable even for those condemned by a judge, let alone for those condemned by a handful of clicks.

Judicial errors exist, but errors in media judgments adopted by those who inform and by makeshift popular juries via social media are much more frequent and dangerous.

A couple of events that have unfolded in rapid succession in recent hours tell this well and dramatically resemble thousands of others that now occur daily. The first, not to dwell on the Ferragnez, until a few days ago – and, after all, still today – one of the most social couples in the country, concerns Fedez, who showcased, in his video podcast, the face of an alleged serial hater – an "hater" as it is now said – addressing him with unspeakable epithets, only to later discover that the person in question was not who he had assumed. No one was hurt, but this does not diminish the seriousness of what...

happened and in the ways whose consequences are difficult to control once popular reactions are triggered, so to speak. The second concerns social media and prestigious newspapers that have bounced everywhere the image of a girl who allegedly pushed a cat into a fountain, only to later acknowledge that the girl in question had the sole fault of sharing a name with the person responsible for the act against the animal.

And this latter incident brings us to the final consideration: professional media, traditional printed and online newspapers, radio and television, while they are in the midst of an identity crisis and questioning their future, amidst the infosphere that devours them and the advancing artificial intelligence, perhaps, should consider whether it is worth distinguishing themselves by stopping the chase after the social media buzz and returning to quality journalism.

The kind that does not splash on the front page the photo of the face of a girl responsible for the drowning of a cat in a fountain without any shred of verification and does not serve as a sounding board for a story, to grant everything, worthy of a neighborhood newsletter, about a review, true or false as it may be, of a pizzeria in the Lodi area without having sufficiently founded elements.